

Limitations of Anonymous Self-Reported Admissions Data

One of the biggest challenges with using GradCafe data is that all submissions are anonymous and self-reported. Because there is no verification process, there is no way to know whether every entry is completely accurate. Some applicants may accidentally enter incorrect information, while others may choose not to include details such as GPA, GRE scores, or other background information. During this project, I also noticed that many records contained missing values, which can affect averages and other statistics. In addition, data collected through web scraping is not always perfectly structured, so some information may be parsed incorrectly or require additional cleaning and standardization before it can be analyzed.

Some of the results were interesting and somewhat surprising when compared to published admissions statistics. For example, the average GPA and test scores in the dataset appear higher than what might be expected from the overall applicant population. A likely explanation is that applicants who receive positive admission decisions are more motivated to share their results online, while applicants with less favorable outcomes may choose not to post. This creates a selection bias that can make the dataset look stronger than reality. I also found that some university and program names required standardization, and small inconsistencies in the original data can influence the final analysis. For these reasons, the results should be viewed as useful insights into GradCafe submissions rather than an exact representation of all graduate school applicants.